Once we agree that India does matter, the issue that naturally follows is what it takes to ensure it matters more. That naturally is the focus of its national security strategy and foreign policy. The answer in such cases often begins at home. A nation that sets its house in order clearly counts for more in the global discourse. Some of that pertains to the quality of governance, some to the development of capabilities. Any progress in addressing long-standing vulnerabilities, such as in Jammu & Kashmir, is naturally welcome.

Where its periphery is concerned, stronger structural linkages expand the space for India's activities. A more integrated region offers the benefit to all but not least to the largest player. This can be best realized through highlighting the attraction of cooperation as well as the costs of alienation. The extended neighbourhoods that represent the next circle also need sustained attention. It is only if they are treated with the priority of immediate neighbours that India can widen its reach. That they are not so proximate also means a more bespoke policy. With the rest of the world, working with all the major powers gives India the most advantage.

But India's own growing footprint is also being driven by demands of engagement from the world. Given its institutional limitations, an efficient method of engagement is to develop more group interfaces. We see that happening as India interacts collectively with ASEAN, the EU, Eurasia, Africa, the Gulf, Pacific Islands, the Caribbean and the Nordic states. These are being increasingly supplemented by plurilateral groupings like the Quad, the I2U2 and BRICS. The bottom line is that India has, at last, broken out of the box that its competitors helped devise. A 360-degree engagement is one more reason why India matters.

For a country that has the history, scale and ambition of India, the games that nations play have to be developed to a higher level. Understanding and exploiting global dynamics is a critical aspect of that exercise. And this is exceptionally challenging because the world is in the midst of a fundamental transition. The reality of an unfolding multipolarity is tempered by the frictions of a more bipolar overlay. On many questions, the narrative can also be shaped by a larger set of players of varying sizes. As a consequence, India has to simultaneously pursue a range of approaches, some of which may appear contradictory on surface.

As a foundational goal, it must strive to promote greater multipolarity and stronger rebalancing. That will happen faster if it has many well-